
Children's books with Black main characters down 8% in a year, study shows

Only 150 of 2,189 titles published in UK for young children last year focused on minority ethnic, disabled or neurodivergent characters

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Just 47 of the 2,189 books published for under-10s in 2025 featured a Black main character, Photograph: MBI/Alamy

The number of children's books featuring Black main characters fell by almost 8% last year, according to research into diversity in UK publishing.

Just 47 – or 2.1% – of the 2,189 books published for under-10s in 2025 featured a Black main character, a 7.8% fall from the previous year, according to Inclusive Books for Children. Black children make up about 8.5% of that age bracket in England and Wales.

Representation of south Asian main characters fell by 14.3 percentage points to 1.4%, despite children of south Asian heritage making up about 12.4% of the population of under-10s. Just three books featured main characters of Middle Eastern and North African (MENA) heritage, down 50% from the previous year. This represented 0.1% of surveyed books, compared with the group's 2.2% share of the population.

The research by the literacy charity found that only 150 books – 6.9% of those surveyed – featured main characters from minority ethnic, disabled or neurodivergent backgrounds. Of these, 37.3% were written or illustrated by creators who did not share the background of their characters.

The author Serena Patel said: “At an age when children are figuring out the world around them and where they fit in, it's vital they have access to funny, inspiring, adventurous books that reflect both the lives they live and the ones they don't. We must do better.”

The report surveyed baby and toddler books, picture books and fiction for children aged up to nine. It found that representation of disabled characters in picture books fell sharply: the number with disabled main characters dropped by 60% in 2025, to just two titles. Neither was by a disabled creator.

The survey also highlighted what it described as a lack of “incidental representation”: stories in which a main character's identity does not explicitly drive the plot of the story.

Dr Stella Louis, an early years consultant, trainer and author, pointed to this “continued reliance” on books where identity itself was the story. “Why can't a child simply be south Asian, disabled, neurodivergent or bilingual and also be the hero of an ordinary story about friendship, adventure, loss or joy?” she said.

The report found that all three books published in 2025 with MENA main characters were refugee narratives. The study authors said children of MENA heritage needed stories covering a broader range of themes and experiences.

“As an Arab author, it is painful to see the number of children's fiction books representing our region decline from six to only three in 2025,” said Nadine Kaadan. She said the fact that all three books published were focused on refugee experiences risked reinforcing a “single story” about the region, defining it through “war and displacement rather than our rich cultures and heritage”.

There were some signs of progress. Neurodivergent representation increased in picture books, from three titles in 2024 to 13 last year. In the baby and toddler category, the number of books with marginalised main characters rose by 29.4%.

Jake Hope, a children’s book consultant, said: “When children’s enjoyment of reading is at a significant low, it’s more important than ever that the stories children encounter reflect their lives, identities, experiences and emotions.

“These figures need to be more than mere statistics and a call to action for continued change and improvements.”

This article was amended on 5 October 2026. In an earlier version Serena Patel was misidentified as Sheena Patel. This has been corrected, and an image of Sheena Patel removed. The first name of Jake Hope was also corrected.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
figures	n.	数据、数字	“These figures need to be more than mere statistics” 这些数字不能只是统计数字；figures 也指“人物、身材”，新闻中作“数据”解极高频
published	v.	出版；发布	“the 2,189 books published for under-10s” 为十岁以下儿童出版的 2,189 种书；报告、数据“发布”也用 publish（第二义项）
feature	v.	以……为主角；重点呈现	“books featuring Black main characters” 以黑人儿童为主角的书；名词 feature 另义“（报纸）特稿、专题”
surveyed	v.	受访的、被调研的	“6.9% of those surveyed” 受访书目中的 6.9%；survey 作名词“调查、概览”
representation	n.	代表性、呈现	“Representation of south Asian main characters fell” 南亚裔

词	词性	中文	备注
			主角的呈现比例下降；动词 represent
fall	n.	下降、跌幅	“a 7.8% fall from the previous year” 较上年下跌 7.8%；动词 fall“落下、下跌”
percentage points	n.	百分点	“fell by 14.3 percentage points” 下降 14.3 个百分点；百分点≠百分比（percent），比较数据时的易混点
share	n.	占比、份额	“the group’s 2.2% share of the population” 该群体占人口的 2.2%；另义“股份、分享”
decline	v./n.	减少、下降	“decline from six to only three in 2025” 2025 年从六种降至仅三种；另义“婉拒”
drop	v.	骤降、跌落	“dropped by 60% in 2025, to just two titles” 2025 年骤降 60%，仅剩两种；名词“下降、一滴”
minority ethnic	adj.	少数族裔的	“characters from minority ethnic, disabled or neurodivergent backgrounds” 少数族裔、残障或神经多样性背景的角色；英式常用名词 ethnic minority
neurodivergent	adj.	神经多样性的（自闭症、ADHD 等）	“Neurodivergent representation increased in picture books” 绘本中的神经多样性呈现增加
incidental	adj.	附带性的、非主线的	“a lack of ‘incidental representation’” 缺乏“顺带式呈现”（主角身份不刻意成为主题

词	词性	中文	备注
			的写法)；incident 事件
marginalised	adj.	被边缘化的	“books with marginalised main characters rose by 29.4%” 以边缘群体为主角的书增加 29.4%
literacy	n.	读写能力、（阅读）推广	“the literacy charity” 该阅读推广慈善机构；literate 识字的
drive	v.	推动、驱动	“identity does not explicitly drive the plot” 身份并不直接推动情节；名词 driver“驱动因素”
bracket	n.	（年龄）组、区间	“that age bracket” 那个年龄组；另义“括号、支架”
single story	n.	“单一故事”（以偏概全的刻板叙事）	“risked reinforcing a ‘single story’ about the region” 可能强化对该地区的单一叙事；语出 Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie 演讲 The Danger of a Single Story
amended	v.	更正、修订	“This article was amended on 5 October 2026” 本文于 2026 年 10 月 5 日更正；名词 amendment 修正案，法律条文“修订”亦用此词
call to action	n.	行动号召	“a call to action for continued change and improvements” 呼吁继续推动改变与改进；缩写 CTA